Development and Characterisation of Eggshell–Agar Biocomposites for Sustainable Interior Applications

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ICSMMEP-26 · MECCA · 3–4 NOVEMBER 2026



THE POSITION EGGSHELL OCCUPIES

The filler was already bio-based. The binder was not.

ESTABLISHED PRACTICE

Mineral phase

waste eggshell, 5–30% of matrix

Binding phase

Portland clinker · bitumen · lime · ceramic body · PLA, epoxy, PVC, PU

The waste stream is valorised. The matrix remains petrochemical, clinker-based or ceramic.

THIS STUDY

Mineral phase

waste eggshell, 66% of solids

Binding phase

agar, plasticised with glycerol — biological and biodegradable

Both phases are biological. The composite returns to a biological cycle intact.

Teara et al. 2019 · Adogla et al. 2016 · Razzaq & Yousif 2017 · Soundara & Vilasini 2015 · Vilarinho et al. 2022 · Owuamanam & Cree 2020

WHAT IS ALREADY KNOWN

EGGSHELL — ESTABLISHED USES

Application	Matrix	Reference
Cement replacement	Portland clinker	Teara et al. 2019
Laterite brick stabilisation	Cement	Adogla et al. 2016
Asphalt binder modification	Bitumen	Razzaq & Yousif 2017
Soil stabilisation	Lime substitute	Soundara & Vilasini 2015
Eco-ceramic wall tile	Ceramic body	Vilarinho et al. 2022
Particulate filler	PLA, epoxy, PVC, PU	Owuamanam & Cree 2020

~94% calcium carbonate; porous, protein-bound crystalline structure; specific gravity 0.85–2.66. The material argument is settled.

AGAR — CHARACTERISED, BUT AS A FILM

Hernández et al. (2022) mapped 32 agar–glycerin–water formulations by design of experiments and released the dataset openly. Glycerol raises elongation and lowers tensile strength.

—	Film literature	This study
Form	Thin cast film	Cast solid, 20–50 mm
Filler	Unfilled	Mineral, 66% of solids
Loading	Uniaxial tension	Compression, bending
Use	Packaging	Interior surfaces

The compositional logic carries over. The form, the filler and the loading case do not.

THE GAP, MEASURED

A commons four recipes deep.

Materiom publishes biomaterial recipes under CC-BY-SA, excludes petrochemical ingredients, archives each as prior art, and indexes property data with citable DOIs. The infrastructure for shared procedures is built.

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recipes with published property data

WHICH ARE

agar bioplastic
gelatin bioplastic
mycelium–walnut shell
mussel shell–sucrose ceramic

WHAT THAT MEANS HERE

The nearest analogue is the mussel shell–sucrose ceramic: a shell mineral in a biological binder. Nothing couples a shell mineral to an agar binder. Nothing reports compressive, flexural, ignitability and hygric data for one formulation family.

The contribution is a protocol and a property set entering that commons.

materiom.org/data, accessed October 2026

AIM AND QUESTIONS

To document a reproducible production protocol for a fully bio-based eggshell composite, and to characterise its mechanical, thermal and hygric response against conventional and bio-based interior materials.

SCOPE

- Five formulations, two mechanical programmes
- Three specimens per formulation
- ASTM D790-17 · ISO 11925-2 · ASTM D570
- Single laboratory, ambient curing, no ageing

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

01 Which formulation variable governs compressive strength?

02 What is the effect of plasticiser content on flexural behaviour?

03 How does it compare with conventional interior materials?

04 How does it compare with other bio-based composites?

05 Is compressive strength the appropriate criterion at all?

PRODUCTION PROTOCOL

One cook, then eleven days at room temperature.

120 °C	95 °C	80 °C	23 °C
20 min	← 55 min →		11 days
01 **Mineral fraction**	02 **Binder phase**	03 **Compositing**	04 **Casting and cure**
– Clean of membrane and residue	– Water and glycerol pre-mixed	– Temperature reduced, stirring kept	– Silicone moulds, no parting agent
– Heat-treat: decontamination and drying	– Agar added incrementally, stirred	– Viscosity develops	– Four days in mould
– Dry to constant mass	– Held until fully in solution	– Shell fraction added incrementally	– Demoulded, seven days ambient
– Mill to homogeneous powder	– Bulk addition forms agglomerates	– Earlier addition lets it sediment	– No oven at any stage
– Sieve, 150 µm passing fraction			



DISCLOSURE — DIMENSIONAL LOSS

The composite shrinks appreciably as water evaporates. Cross-sections were measured at test time, but post-drying dimensions were not logged, so dimensions quoted here are mould dimensions. Stirring was manual: shear rate and mixing energy are not controlled quantities.

CONSTITUENTS AND FORMULATIONS

WHAT EACH COMPONENT DOES

Constituent	Origin	Function	Relevant property
Eggshell powder	Food waste	Mineral filler; carries load	94% $CaCO_3$; porous structure
Agar	Red seaweed	Continuous binding phase	Thermoreversible gel
Glycerol	Vegetable oil	Plasticiser; sets ductility	Humectant; low vapour pressure
Water	—	Carrier; sets solids packing	Fully evaporated on drying
Shellac	Kerria lacca	Hydrophobic surface finish	Biodegradable film-former

Water is not a component of the finished material. It is the process variable that sets how densely the solids pack.

FORMULATION MATRIX

ID	Test	Water g	Shell g	Agar g	Glycerol g	Solids g	Shell : binder	Solids : water	Glycerol % solids
C1	Compression	325	80	35	5	120	**2.00**	0.37	4.2
C2	Compression	310	90	40	5	135	**2.00**	0.44	3.7
C3	Compression	280	110	45	10	165	**2.00**	0.59	6.1
F1	Flexure	450	190	70	60	320	1.46	0.71	18.8
F2	Flexure	480	190	70	30	290	1.90	0.60	10.3

Shell : binder is held at exactly 2.00 across the compression series. The only variable is solids concentration.

Glycerol was halved at fixed batch mass, so water rose with it: the plasticiser effect is not isolated.

TEST PROGRAMME

Property	Standard	Specimen	n	Measured
Compressive behaviour	Cube compression	50 mm cube moulds	3 per mix	Max load; compressive stress
Flexural behaviour	ASTM D790-17	180 × 60 × 20 mm, 120 mm span	3 per mix	Flexural strength; modulus
Reaction to fire	ISO 11925-2:2020	40 × 50 mm, 45°, 15 s edge flame	2	Time to ignition; to extinguish
Water absorption	ASTM D570-98	40 × 50 mm, shellac-coated	1	Mass gain, 24 h immersion
Bulk density	Gravimetric	50 mm cube	1	Mass / mould volume

REPORTING CONVENTION

Mechanical values are means of three specimens; individual specimen values were not retained, so standard deviations cannot be reported. Fire, absorption and density rest on single determinations and are indicative, not characteristic, values.

All testing: Advanced Construction Materials Research Laboratory, Hacettepe University.

COMPRESSION

Strength is set by packing density, not mineral content.

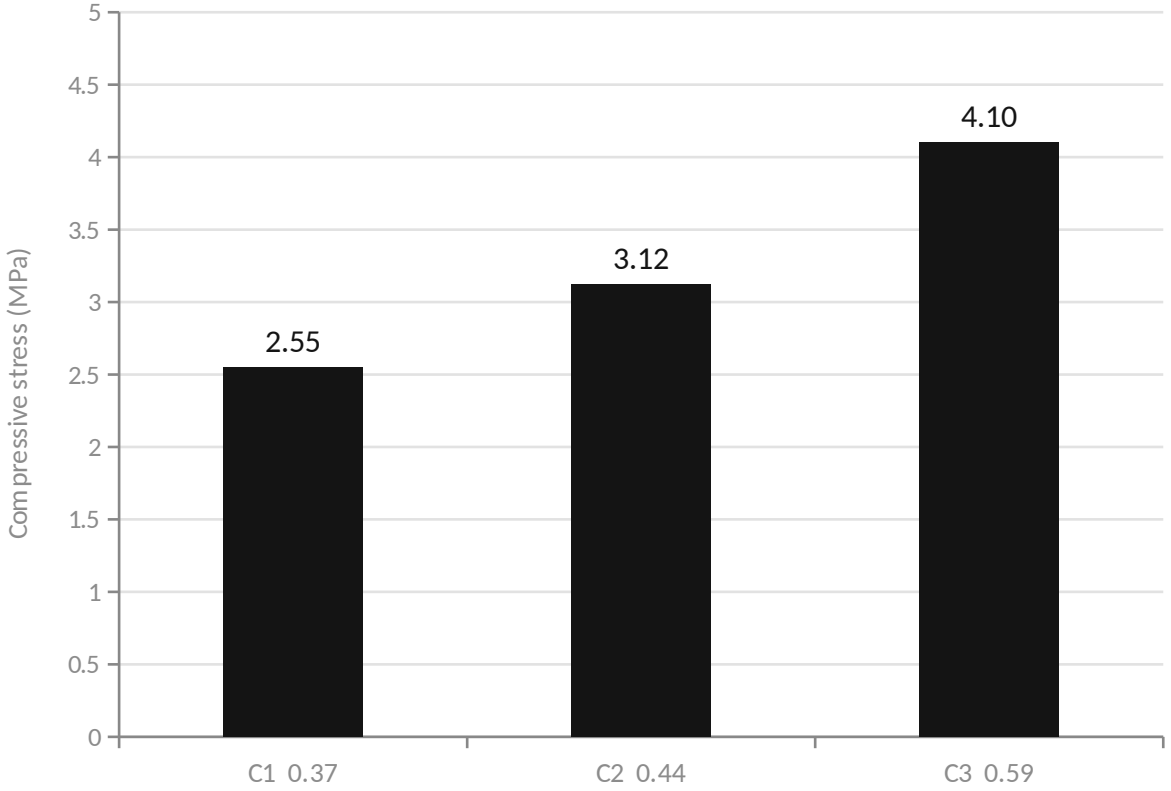
ID	Solids : water	F_{max} kN	σc MPa
C1	0.37	3.89	2.55
C2	0.44	4.30	3.12
C3	0.59	**6.80**	**4.10**

OBSERVED RELATIONSHIP

σc = 6.93 · (solids : water) + 0.04

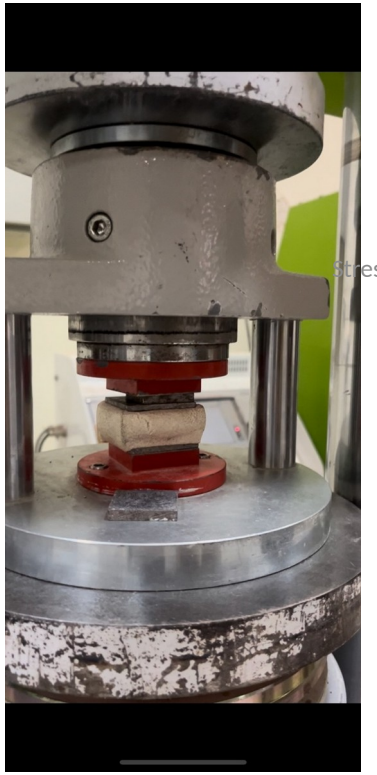
R^2 = 0.994 over 0.37 – 0.59

With shell : binder fixed, compressive stress is linear in solids concentration across the range tested. Three formulations cannot establish a law — but the reading is testable: remove water rather than add shell.



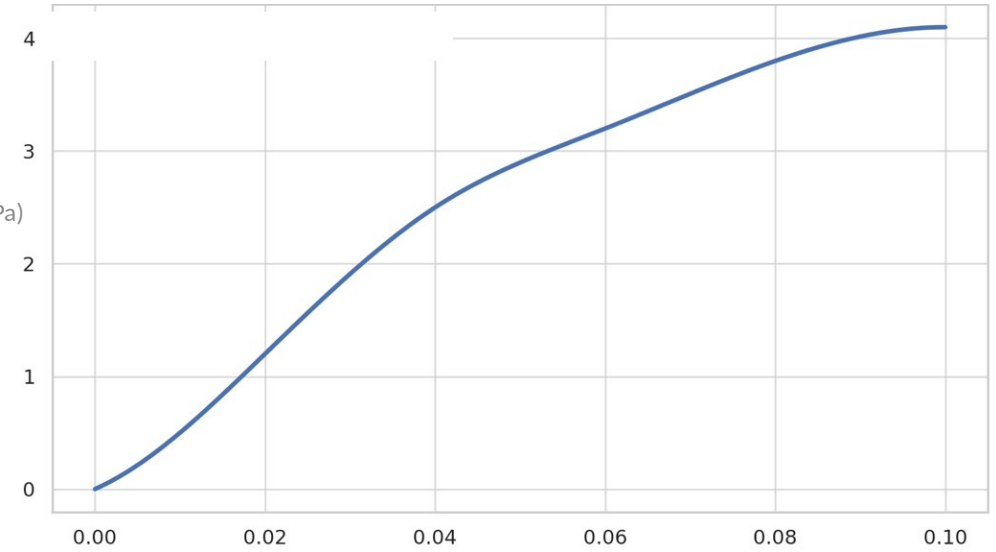
FAILURE MODE

It crushes progressively. It does not fracture.



C3 after loading: barrelled, shortened, intact

COMPRESSIVE STRESS – STRAIN, C3



1.38 g/cm³ · 2.96 MPa per g/cm³

Bulk density on a mould-volume basis, therefore a lower bound.

READING THE CURVE

- Linear elastic to approximately 1 MPa
- Progressive stiffness loss as the agar network yields
- Peak at roughly 10% strain, no abrupt load drop
- Beyond peak: deformation with retained integrity

Strain derived from an assumed 10% maximum deformation based on observation, not instrumented measurement.

Plasticiser content decides whether the material resists at all.

ID	Glycerol % solids	F_{max} N	σ_F MPa	E_F MPa	ε peak
F1	18.8	—	*not measurable*	—	—
F2	10.3	310	**2.325**	**192**	0.0121

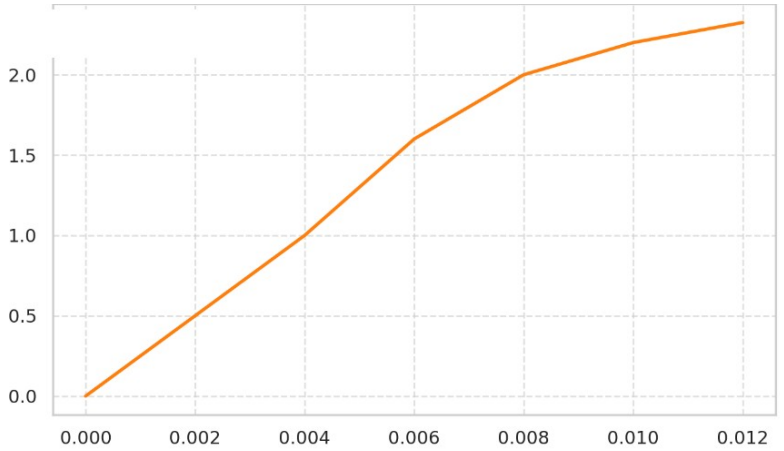
$\sigma_F = 3FL / 2bd^2$ with F = 310 N, L = 120 mm, b = 60 mm, d = 20 mm





Three-point rig; kerfed panel arched by hand

FLEXURAL STRESS – STRAIN, F2

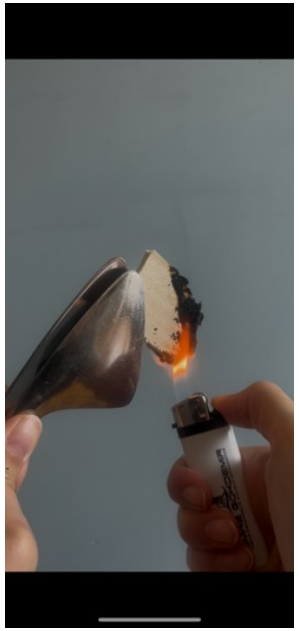


DISCLOSURE — SECTION GEOMETRY

The specimen carries transverse kerfs on its tension face. ASTM D790-17 assumes a solid rectangular section and the calculation uses the full 60 × 20 mm. Part of the measured compliance is geometric, so the modulus is a lower bound.

INTERPRETATION

At 18.8% glycerol the composite deformed without developing measurable resistance. Halving it produced a section that resists while still flexing. The transition lies between these values.



IGNITABILITY — ISO 11925-2

~10 s
to ignition

4 s
to self-extinguish

- Charring local to flame contact
- No lateral flame spread
- No melting, no dripping

Probable mechanism: endothermic carbonate decomposition releasing CO_2, not verified calorimetrically. Ignitability only — no Euroclass, cone calorimetry, smoke or toxicity data.

WATER ABSORPTION — ASTM D570

0.7%

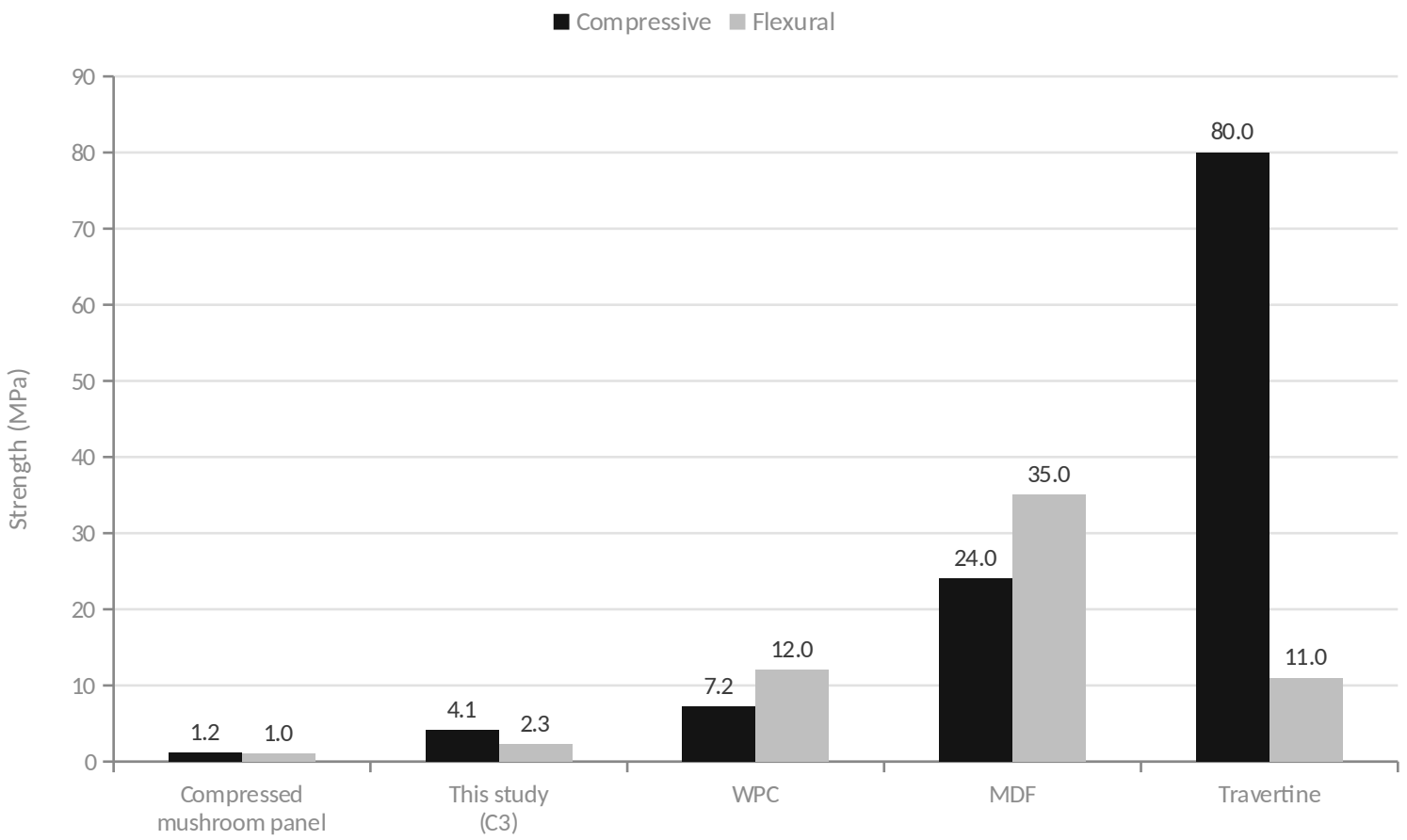
mass gain over 24 h immersion, shellac-coated. Local dissolution where the coating was thin: coating integrity is the limiting factor, not the composite.

BULK DENSITY

Material	g/cm³	Reference
This study (C3)	**1.38**	—
Mycelium, cellulose	0.3 – 0.8	Jones et al. 2020
Fired clay brick	1.6 – 2.0	William & Owen 1995
Normal-weight concrete	2.4	William & Owen 1995

Quoted on a mould-volume basis and therefore a lower bound.

AGAINST CONVENTIONAL INTERIOR MATERIALS



Velasco & Gaona 2011 · Klyosov 2007 · Nemli & Aydın 2007 · Altun 2006

POSITION

One sixth the compressive strength of MDF and one twentieth that of travertine — a stone the material visually resembles. Three times compressed mushroom panel, the only other fully bio-based board here.

On strength alone it does not compete with engineered wood or stone, and this paper does not claim it does.

AGAINST BIO-BASED COMPOSITES

Water-cast and ambient-dried, at melt-processed stiffness.

COMPRESSIVE STRENGTH

Material	σc MPa	Reference
This study (C3)	**4.1**	—
Mycelium composite	0.145 – 0.452	Jones et al. 2020
Hempcrete	0.3 – 0.6	Arnaud & Gourlay 2012
Eggshell-filled PLA	2 – 5	Kim & Pal 2010
Mineral-filled biocomposite	2.1 – 39.6	Shah et al. 2016
30% algae-filled	21.3	Kim & Pal 2010

ELASTIC MODULUS

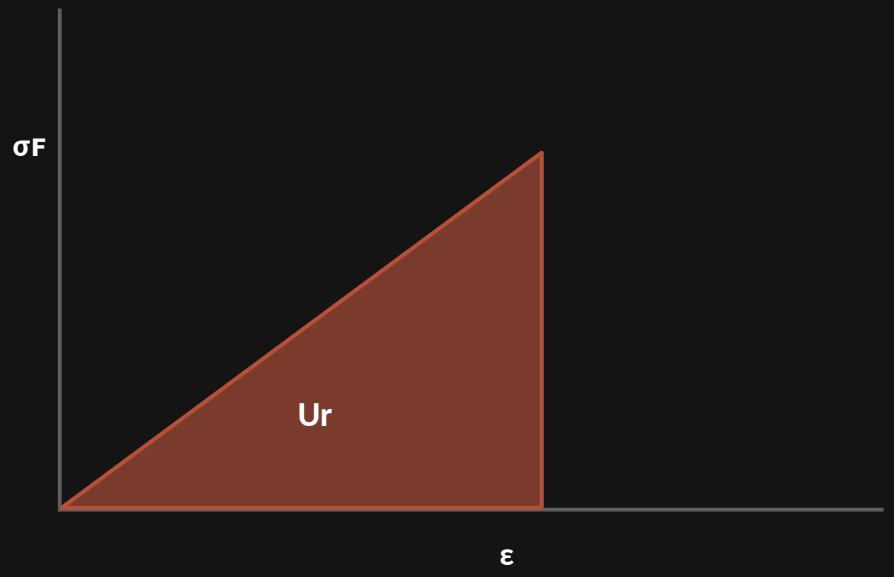
Material	E MPa	Reference
This study (F2)	**192**	—
Mycelium composite	1.8 – 5	Islam et al. 2018
Soy-based bioplastic	124	Mansour et al. 2021
Corn starch + hemp	158	Dweib et al. 2004
Flax-fibre PLA	198	Faruk et al. 2012
LDPE	100 – 300	Zhao et al. 2022
Wood (pine)	11 000	Pope & Hudson 1989

An order of magnitude above the fungal and lime-binder family in compression, and inside the bio-polymer band in stiffness — between soy bioplastic and flax-fibre PLA, within the LDPE range.

Unfilled agar films in the packaging literature sit well below this: the mineral phase, not the binder, carries the stiffness. Wood remains two orders of magnitude above.

A DERIVED PROPERTY

Stiffness sits in the denominator.



Area under the elastic region to yield = ½ σ ε = σ^2 / 2E

THE QUANTITY

$Ur = \sigma F^2 / 2EF$

14.1 kJ/m³

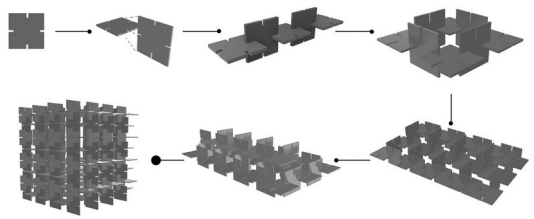
2.325^2 / (2 × 192), from this study's own measured values for F2

The low modulus that counted against the material in the previous benchmark is exactly what raises this quantity.

WHY IT FITS, AND ITS LIMIT

Both programmes gave the same result: substantial deformation with retained integrity. Strength records the load at which a material stops performing, not how it then fails.

A comparative table cannot yet be assembled: the literature reports σ and E in separate studies on different formulations. This is a data point and a measurement convention, not a ranking.





Modular proposal developed from the measured properties

WHAT THE MEASUREMENTS PERMIT

Low strength, high deformation capacity self-weight and handling loads only; no structural duty

Self-extinguishing, no dripping interior surfaces away from ignition sources

Coating-dependent water resistance dry interiors; not wet rooms or facades

Repeatable small-format casting a module, not a sheet — failure is replaced one unit at a time

POTENTIALS FOR SUSTAINABLE INTERIORS

Waste valorisation at source

A local food-waste stream becomes a surface material with no intermediate industry.

Low-energy production

No oven, no autoclave, no extrusion. One 55-minute cook, then ambient drying.

End-of-life by design

Every constituent biodegrades, including the shellac finish.

Reversible assembly

Adhesive-free modular assembly means reuse precedes recycling.

Displacing a mineral extraction

Substitutes quarried limestone in a surface application, not a downcycled use.

Low-barrier manufacture

A grinder, a sieve, a hotplate and silicone moulds. Production can be distributed.

No life-cycle assessment was carried out. These are qualitative potentials grounded in the protocol, not quantified environmental claims.

LIMITATIONS

Dispersion not reported

Means of three specimens; individual values not retained, so no standard deviations.

Formulation confound in flexure

Glycerol, solids concentration and shell : binder moved together between F1 and F2.

Section geometry in flexure

A kerfed specimen treated as a solid rectangle. The modulus is a lower bound.

Strain not instrumented

Compressive strain derived from an assumed 10% maximum deformation.

Shrinkage unquantified

Post-drying dimensions not logged; density is a lower bound.

Process not instrumented

Manual stirring; single laboratory, single operator, no inter-laboratory reproduction.

No durability data

No humidity or thermal cycling, UV exposure, microbial resistance or accelerated ageing.

No fire classification or LCA

Ignitability only; no Euroclass determination and no life-cycle assessment.

Each defines a specific next experiment rather than a general caveat.

CONCLUSIONS

01	**A reproducible protocol**	120 °C shell treatment · 150 µm fraction · 95 °C dissolution · 80 °C cook · 55 min · silicone casting · 11 days ambient
02	**Solids concentration governs strength**	With shell : binder fixed at 2.00, compressive stress is linear in solids concentration across 0.37–0.59
03	**Plasticiser sets the brittle–ductile transition**	Between 18.8% and 10.3% glycerol, from unmeasurable compliance to 2.33 MPa at 192 MPa
04	**Bio-polymer stiffness, oven-free**	192 MPa places a water-cast, ambient-dried material inside the melt-processed bio-polymer band
05	**Strength is the wrong sole criterion**	Deformation capacity governs service behaviour; σ and E should be reported together

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Testing: Advanced Construction Materials Research Laboratory, Hacettepe University, with thanks to Dr Hüseyin İlcan. Derived from the author's doctoral dissertation, Hacettepe University, 2025.

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AGAR AND BIO-POLYMER SYSTEMS

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COMPARATIVE MATERIAL DATA

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- Nemli & Aydın (2007) — MDF. Altun (2006) — travertine. Klyosov (2007) — WPC. Velasco & Gaona (2011) — mushroom panel.

Standards: ASTM D790-17 · ISO 11925-2:2020 · ASTM D570-98(2018).